

THE LOST JAMAICAN · SUBSCRIBER EDITION

How We Build These Videos

The full production system behind the episodes — research, casting, script, shots, stills, motion, voice, sound, thumbnail and the quality gates that decide whether an episode ships or gets rebuilt.

Every rule in here was paid for with a broken episode.

Before anything: the one idea

An episode is not "a video about an artist." It is one **governing contradiction** — the gap between who the world thought someone was and what was actually happening. Everything else serves that gap.

If you cannot say the contradiction in a single sentence, you do not have an episode yet. You have a Wikipedia summary, and audiences leave those in four seconds.

The test: "Everyone knew him as X. What nobody knew was Y." If Y is not surprising, keep researching or pick a different subject.

1. Research before script

Script written from memory is where fabrication enters. Research first, and keep four separate ledgers so you never confuse them:

LEDGER	WHAT GOES IN IT
Facts	Dated, sourced, at least two independent publishers agreeing.
Claims	Widely repeated but single-sourced. Usable only if spoken as disputed.
Hidden gems	True details almost nobody repeats. These are what make the episode worth watching.
Rejected	Things you found and deliberately will not say, with the reason.

The rejected ledger matters most. Writing down *why* you dropped a juicy rumour is what stops you quietly putting it back in at 2am.

2. The anchor pass — casting is decided before shots

Every named person, place and thing is an **anchor**. Before a single frame is generated, each anchor needs a verified reference: a clear, well-lit, face-visible photograph of the actual person, confirmed against at least two sources that agree on who it is.

The rules that came from failures

- **Crop references to the face.** A branded cap or tee in the reference photo reappears in every single scene.
- **No sunglasses, no masks, no obstructions** in the reference — unless the obstruction is genuinely part of the person's identity.
- **Never upscale a small crop.** An enlarged face reads soft and drags likeness down for the whole episode. Cut native, downscale only.
- **One reference per person per shot.** Two references for the same person in a group shot renders them twice.

- **Never lighten anyone's complexion.** Name the actual skin tone in the prompt and check the finished frame against the reference.
- **If no reliable photo exists, shoot off-face.** Hands, silhouette, back of head, the room. Never guess a face.

Hard stop: if the anchor is weak, the whole episode is weak. Fix the reference or change the subject. Do not "push on and see."

3. Script: scene-first, no dates read aloud

Open on a body mid-action, not on a date. Name the expectation, then break it. Use repetition as a drumbeat. Close on the image you opened with.

- Every beat is a fresh turn, measured under **3.5 seconds**.
- Narration lands around **3.3 words per second**. Write to the clock, not the page.
- The cold open states the consequence first, then rewinds to explain it.
- No "in 1979" narration. Dates belong on screen if anywhere.

Every noun is a visual

The rule that fixed more episodes than any other: **if it is spoken, it is on screen while it is spoken**. Every named person, place and thing. If a noun cannot be shown, cut the noun — do not let the narration describe something the viewer cannot see. People are staged, never deleted from the line.

4. Shot list

Shots are derived from the beats, never from a fixed list of shot numbers. A hardcoded set of IDs is how thirty-five of fifty-two shots end up mis-wired.

- One shot per one-to-three beats. In practice: `ceil(seconds / 3.4)`.
- The hero performs the narrated action literally. He does the thing being described.
- The hero never looks down the lens.
- No stranger appears without a verb — if a person is in frame, they are doing something.
- Alternate angles between adjacent shots so the cut has somewhere to go.

5. Stills: identity is the whole game

Stills are generated **image-to-image from the verified reference photograph**. Not text-to-image with a name in the prompt, and not a face swapped on afterwards. Swapping a face onto a finished frame always reads as plastic, and on video the mouth turns to mush.

What actually moves likeness

- **Guidance strength is the real lever**, not step count. More steps buys detail, not resemblance.
- **Denoise matters more than anything**. At full denoise none of the reference pixels survive — you get a stranger who vaguely rhymes with your subject.
- **Wide and medium shots only** for identity work. Close-ups are shot as detail frames without the identity block.
- Score every still against the anchor. Below threshold, re-render. Never ship and hope.

Prompt trap: prohibitions summon what they forbid. Writing "no crowd, nobody in the background" reliably produces a crowd. Describe the empty room positively instead: "a bare room, one chair, morning light."

6. Motion

Stills become clips image-to-video. Keep the engine, resolution and step count frozen for the whole episode — changing the recipe mid-build is how you get an episode where shot 12 does not match shot 13.

- Give each clip a start frame, and an end frame only when it is a face shot. Non-face end frames invent strangers.
- Short clips. Long generations drift.
- Never let two heavy jobs share one GPU. Measured collision: clips went from 70 seconds to 700.

7. Voice and sound

- One consistent narrator voice, mastered to a single loudness target. A call-to-action recorded hotter than the body is the most common audio defect.
- Sound effects carry the world — room tone, street, crowd, vinyl, rain.
- Narration pacing is tightened, not sped up: trim the pauses first.

8. Thumbnail

- Build at **3:4** so it survives every grid crop.
- Keep the name and face inside the safe zone. Instagram crops the top and bottom of a vertical cover and will behead your typography.

- Short words render cleanly; long words garble. Put only words the engine can actually spell.
- The badge is a real call to action, never a label.

9. Quality gates — what blocks a ship

Gates are split into two kinds, and mixing them up will either let defects through or stall you on nothing.

BLOCKING	ADVISORY
Bad anchor reference; invented strangers in frame; per-shot likeness below threshold; thumbnail safe zone; final publication check.	Noun coverage; script-to-visual match; pacing drift; caption length.

A line in a config file claiming a person is present proves nothing. The gate must actually detect the face in the rendered frame, or the name comes out of the script.

10. The habits that save the most time

- **Verify every background job you launch.** Three copies of one batch fighting over one GPU produces nothing, for hours.
- **Keep a failure ledger.** Every failure recorded with its fix, consulted before retrying. The same bug should never cost you time twice.
- **Fix means replace.** A distorted clip gets a clean re-render. Never mask a defect with a filter.
- **Locks are defaults, not walls.** If the look is wrong, fix it, write down what changed, and move on.
- **Never restart the model server mid-episode** unless you have measured that it is actually stuck.

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